

1 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

A picnic for three toys

What we are practising

Match one object to each guest and count a small set.

What you need

Three soft toys / Three unbreakable cups / Three cloth napkins

Use folded towels as pretend plates.

Before you begin

Seat the toys in a row on the floor.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Give one cup to the first toy and invite your child to finish.
2. Touch and count the cups together: one, two, three.
3. Add one napkin per toy and check whether anyone has none or two.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Does every guest have exactly one cup?

Space to explore

2 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

Sock pair search

What we are practising

Match objects by observable features.

What you need

Three pairs of large clean socks

Match pairs of washcloths with different colours or textures.

Before you begin

Separate and mix the socks on a clear surface.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Pick one sock and describe its colour and pattern.
2. Invite your child to find its partner and place them together.
3. Repeat, then count the pairs rather than individual socks.

Talk, draw or show your idea

What makes these two a pair?

Space to explore

3 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Clap and count

What we are practising

Link number words to individual actions.

What you need

No materials

Tap a knee or blink instead of clapping.

Before you begin

Choose a comfortable seated or standing position.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Clap twice slowly while saying “one, two”.
2. Ask your child to copy, then try one or three claps.
3. Let your child lead a small group of claps for you to count.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Can we make exactly three taps and then stop?

Space to explore

4 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

Long and short paths

What we are practising

Compare lengths using a shared starting point.

What you need

Two towels of different lengths

Use two strips of paper laid flat.

Before you begin

Roll the towels and place one end of each at the same line.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Trace each path with a finger, starting at the shared line.
2. Ask which reaches farther and name it longer.
3. Move one towel forward, then realign the starts before comparing again.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Why should the paths start in the same place?

Space to explore

5 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 10 minutes

Shape parking spaces

What we are practising

Recognise circles, triangles and squares by their outlines.

What you need

Paper / Crayons / Three large shape cards prepared by an adult

Draw all shapes and point to matches instead of using cards.

Before you begin

Draw one circle, triangle and square on a sheet and on separate large cards.

Stay with your child and use large, intact, age-appropriate materials.

Try it together

1. Trace a circle and notice its curved edge.
2. Match each card to its parking space.
3. Turn the square card and ask whether it still belongs in the square space.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Which shape has three straight sides?

Space to explore

6 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Count only the red boats

What we are practising

Count a selected subgroup.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Imagine two red toy boats and one blue boat. How many boats are red?

Space to explore

7 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

One guest joins

What we are practising

Add one to a small group.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Two toys sit at a table. One more toy joins them. How many toys sit there now?

Space to explore

8 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

A bird flies away

What we are practising

Subtract one from a small set.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Three birds sit on a fence. One flies away. How many remain on the fence?

Space to explore

9 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Which plate has more?

What we are practising

Compare two small quantities.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

One pretend plate has four berries; another has two. Which plate has more berries?

Space to explore

10 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

An empty nest count

What we are practising

Use zero to describe none.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Two pretend eggs are in a nest. Both are moved to another nest. How many are left in the first?

Space to explore

11 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

The taller block tower

What we are practising

Compare height with equal units.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Two towers use identical blocks. One stacks three blocks; the other stacks one. Which is taller?

Space to explore

12 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Full, empty or partly full?

What we are practising

Compare simple capacity states.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

A cup contains water only halfway up. Is it empty, completely full or partly full?

Space to explore

13 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

The toy in the middle

What we are practising

Identify a position between two items.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Three toys stand in a row: bear, rabbit, cat. Which toy is between the other two?

Space to explore

14 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

First in the pretend line

What we are practising

Use first and last in an ordered set.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

At a pretend door, duck waits first, bear second and cat third. Who enters first?

Space to explore

15 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Spread-out stars

What we are practising

Recognise that spacing does not change count.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

There are three drawn stars. An adult redraws the same three farther apart. Are there more stars now?

Space to explore

16 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Find the square's corners

What we are practising

Count the corners of a familiar shape.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Trace a square in the air. How many corners does a square have?

Space to explore

17 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Choose a box that fits

What we are practising

Compare size for a practical purpose.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

A large toy cannot fit inside a tiny box. Would a larger empty box be a better first choice?

Space to explore

18 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

The missing counting word

What we are practising

Continue the counting sequence.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Listen: one, two, ..., four. Which number word belongs in the gap?

Space to explore

19 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Count all the sounds

What we are practising

Count a mixed set of events.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

You hear two gentle taps and one clap. How many sounds did you hear altogether?

Space to explore

20 / 20 | Ages 3-4 | 5 minutes

Make the rows equal

What we are practising

Notice equality between small groups.

What you need

No materials

Draw the scene or point to imagined choices if speaking is difficult.

Before you begin

An adult reads the whole question; pause to explain unfamiliar words.

An adult stays with the child, reads aloud and accepts pointing or gestures.

Try it together

1. Read the question below and identify what you need to find.
2. Try an answer; show your thinking with words, fingers or a quick drawing.
3. Use the hint if needed, then compare with the answer and explain why it fits.

Talk, draw or show your idea

One row has two drawn circles. Another has two drawn squares. Do the rows have the same number of shapes?

Space to explore

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

1. A picnic for three toys

A little hint

Point to each guest and its place in turn.

Answer / what to notice

Three guests need three cups and three napkins, one each.

Pairing guests and cups lets us check the count without guessing.

Make it easier

Begin with two toys.

Take it further

Add a fourth guest and work out what is missing.

Another day, away from the screen

Help count places at a real family meal.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

2. Sock pair search

A little hint

Compare length and pattern as well as colour.

Answer / what to notice

Three pairs contain six socks; each pair has two matching socks.

Matching may use more than one feature when colours are similar.

Make it easier

Use two very different pairs.

Take it further

Add a sock without a partner and identify it.

Another day, away from the screen

Let your child help match the next small laundry load.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

3. Clap and count

A little hint

Move one finger for each sound.

Answer / what to notice

Three taps means three separate sounds; the pause signals the end.

Slow, separate actions make one-to-one counting easier to follow.

Make it easier

Keep every group to one or two actions.

Take it further

Try groups up to five without speeding up.

Another day, away from the screen

Count gentle steps between two nearby places.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

4. Long and short paths

A little hint

Line up the near ends before looking at the far ends.

Answer / what to notice

The path extending farther from an aligned start is longer.

Moving an object changes its position, not its length.

Make it easier

Use paths with a large difference in length.

Take it further

Put three paths in order from shortest to longest.

Another day, away from the screen

Compare two books' heights by lining up their bottoms.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

5. Shape parking spaces

A little hint

Trace and count one side at a time.

Answer / what to notice

A triangle has three sides; turning a square does not change it into a different shape.

An outline's features matter more than its colour or direction.

Make it easier

Match just circles and squares.

Take it further

Draw a taller triangle and find its family.

Another day, away from the screen

Spot these shapes on familiar packaging together.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

6. Count only the red boats

A little hint

Leave the blue boat out of this count.

Answer / what to notice

Two red boats.

The question asks about red boats, not all three boats.

Make it easier

Show two red marks and one blue mark on paper.

Take it further

How many boats are there altogether?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

7. One guest joins

A little hint

Start with two fingers, then add one.

Answer / what to notice

Three toys.

Two and one more make three.

Make it easier

Count the fingers together slowly.

Take it further

What if one more toy arrives after that?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

8. A bird flies away

A little hint

Show three fingers and fold one down.

Answer / what to notice

Two birds remain.

Removing one from three leaves two.

Make it easier

An adult folds the finger while the child counts.

Take it further

What if the bird returns?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

9. Which plate has more?

A little hint

Pair one berry from each plate in your imagination.

Answer / what to notice

The plate with four.

After pairing two on each side, the first plate still has two extra.

Make it easier

Draw the berries in two rows.

Take it further

How many fewer berries are on the second plate?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

10. An empty nest count

A little hint

None are left there.

Answer / what to notice

Zero eggs.

Zero is the number we use when no items remain.

Make it easier

Say “none” first, then connect it to zero.

Take it further

Add one imaginary egg and say the new count.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

11. The taller block tower

A little hint

Imagine both towers starting on the same floor.

Answer / what to notice

The three-block tower.

More identical stacked blocks give greater height here.

Make it easier

Draw both towers with matching square sizes.

Take it further

How many blocks must join the shorter tower to match?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

12. Full, empty or partly full?

A little hint

There is some water and some space.

Answer / what to notice

Partly full.

It is not empty because water is present, and not full because space remains.

Make it easier

Draw the water line in a cup outline.

Take it further

Describe what completely full would look like.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

13. The toy in the middle

A little hint

Look at the toy with one neighbour on each side.

Answer / what to notice

The rabbit.

Bear and cat are at the ends; rabbit occupies the middle.

Make it easier

Draw three faces in the stated order.

Take it further

Which toy would be in the middle if rabbit and bear swapped?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

14. First in the pretend line

A little hint

The first toy is closest to the door.

Answer / what to notice

Duck.

First describes position in the line, not size or speed.

Make it easier

Use only duck and bear.

Take it further

Who enters last if the order stays the same?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

15. Spread-out stars

A little hint

Count the stars, not the spaces.

Answer / what to notice

No; there are still three.

Changing the gaps does not add or remove a star.

Make it easier

Match each old star to one new star.

Take it further

Would a longer row always contain more things?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

16. Find the square's corners

A little hint

Pause once at each corner.

Answer / what to notice

Four corners.

A square has four sides meeting at four corners.

Make it easier

An adult draws a large square to trace.

Take it further

Does turning the square change its number of corners?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

17. Choose a box that fits

A little hint

The box needs enough space around the toy.

Answer / what to notice

Yes, a larger box is worth trying; it still needs checking.

Larger capacity may solve the fit problem, but the opening and shape also matter.

Make it easier

Compare a clearly tiny and a clearly roomy drawn box.

Take it further

Could a large box with a tiny opening still be difficult?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

18. The missing counting word

A little hint

Count three fingers slowly from one.

Answer / what to notice

Three.

Three follows two and comes before four in counting.

Make it easier

Say one, two, three together, then repeat the question.

Take it further

Continue the sequence one step after four.

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

19. Count all the sounds

A little hint

Count each tap and the clap once.

Answer / what to notice

Three sounds.

Different kinds of sounds can belong to one total: two plus one.

Make it easier

The adult makes the sounds slowly while showing fingers.

Take it further

Would making the clap louder change the count?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

20. Make the rows equal

A little hint

Compare how many, not what shape.

Answer / what to notice

Yes; both rows have two.

The shapes differ, but their quantities are equal.

Make it easier

Point to one circle and one square as a pair.

Take it further

Add a circle in your imagination; are the rows still equal?

Another day, away from the screen

Another day, change one detail and explain whether the answer changes.